The next few years would bring major changes, both for Peres and Israel at large. Likud swept to power in 1977, unseating Labor for the first time in Israel's history. Prime Minister Menachem Begin would soon rapidly expand the settlement enterprise in the West Bank and Gaza—but also sign a peace treaty with Egypt and agree to withdraw from Sinai.

And Peres, the hawk who gave Israel the bomb, would start his journey to the left. Perhaps the pivotal moment came in September 1982, after the Sabra and Shatila massacre in Lebanon, when he spoke at Peace Now's massive anti-war rally in Tel Aviv. "Never have we stood before such a string of wretched decisions that arouse such doubt, sorrow, and mistrust," he said.

Two years later, a close election would force him into a power-sharing agreement with Likud. It was dubbed the *rotatzia*; a cartoonist for the *Jerusalem Post* portrayed it as a horse with a head on each end. The one on the right, Yitzhak Shamir, wanted to build widely in the West Bank. Peres pushed back. They eventually reached a compromise: the government would authorize six of the twenty-seven settlements currently in the planning phase.

Peres never really explained the source of his leftward drift. Cynics would say that he simply read the writing on the wall: surely he had no future as a hawk committed to maintaining a Greater Israel, not with Likud willing to make territorial concessions. Labor had never been in the opposition before. It needed to draw a sharp contrast with the new government, particularly on the crucial issues of war and peace. So politics undoubtedly played a role—but so did experience. In interviews and public appearances, Peres always seemed genuinely convinced that his pivot was necessary and right.

There was a personal component, too. Peres helped Begin sell the Camp David Accords, the peace treaty with Egypt, fighting against both the right and the hawkish members of his own party. He was rewarded for his efforts with threats and scurrilous rumors. In the months before the 1981 general election, Likud activists threw stones at his car, and circulated a "shameful" story: his mother, they said, was really an Arab. "He wanted to be loved, but about half the country got up in arms against him," said his biographer, Michael Bar-Zohar. "He was admired by half of the country, and bitterly criticized by the other half. He got used to that."